

damage to the caster(s). Obviously, the DM should describe the failure and damage with flair and gusto.

Amount of Healing/Damage: How many hp worth of effect (healing or damage) does the player want to produce? DC for the attempt = 5 x number of HP.

Attacks against the PCs: PCs roll to defend/block/dodge (generally Defense + Toughness for physical attacks or Defense + Magic against magical attacks) against a DC based on the attacking creature's characteristics (e.g. Dragons are Hard to Very Hard in all areas; Humanoids are Average in most areas; and small or frail creatures have easy DCs for physical attacks) Do the same thing for Saving Throws against NPC abilities as appropriate.

PCs Dealing Damage: Players declare their attacks and hit automatically (Natural 1's always miss), with damage determined by the value of the roll. Attacks deal 1 point of damage per Tier above Easy.

PCs Taking Damage: NPC attacks deal flat damage based on the creature and type of attack. PCs defensive rolls reduce damage by 1 point per Tier above Average.

Combined Efforts: If PC's wish to cooperate on a task for which it is plausible to do so, reduce the Tier by 1 for each helper. The attempt is successful ONLY if all participants meet the new DC. If any participants, do not meet the new DC, the attempt fails.

Dungeon Master's Guide

Core Conditions and Considerations of this Ruleset:

- requires players to have NO background knowledge of the rules of play. ALL of the burden of rule adjudication is carried by the DM.
- is designed to allow players to fill out their character sheet in 5 minutes or less and begin play immediately after.
- assumes a 1-shot adventure with no future sessions. Therefore, character growth or increase in strength is highly compressed and punctuated.
- After this 1-shot, players will have gotten a genuine taste of D&D and what thrills would await them in a full campaign.
- is fully dependent on the DM's intuition regarding the relative difficulty of the intended actions. (Minimalist monster statblocks are provided for convenience.)

Rule Zero, Understanding how to DM this Ruleset:

Because there is no rulebook defining the mechanics of particular in-world actions or interactions, the players are constrained only by what you present and allow, and by what solutions they propose. You can present ANY challenge, and the players can present ANY solution and you adjudicate based on the following guidelines for difficulty. When considering the difficulty of a given challenge, the important thing to remember is that this scale is assessed relative to the party. Thus, an adventure with "stronger" characters will have more mundane tasks with lower DCs while an adventure with "weaker" characters will have comparatively higher DCs for similar tasks.

However, note that the players have no reference point for “strong” or “weak” so their perceived power level is entirely in relation to the difficulty of the world you present them and what they’re able to successfully pull off.

Types of Rolls	Any two Dice, Minimum Possible	Average Affinity, no Proficiency	Strong Affinity and Proficient	Perfect Maximum Rolls
Avg Roll	2	15	22	32

Difficulty for PCs of this Power Level (Tier)	Very Easy (1)	Easy (2)	Average (3)	Hard (4)	Very Hard (5)	Miracle (6)
Target DC	5	10	15	20	25	30

For Example:

For DMs familiar with D&D, it can be helpful to consider Target Party Level (TPL), which is the level the PCs would be if you were playing by D&D rules. This Character Sheet as written should be roughly compatible with D&D 5e at a TPL of 1-4 with respect. For higher TPL, spells, bonuses, and hit points should be increased to better align with stats for D&D characters at those levels.

For an action that would be available to a PC at the TPL in D&D 5th edition, assign an Average DC (15). For each character level higher (or lower) that would be required in D&D, increase (or decrease) the DC by 5.

Suppose a DM is planning an adventure that would be appropriate for a 3rd level party in D&D (TPL = 3). A 3rd level party should have average difficulty with challenges at CR 2-4 and great difficulty with challenges at level 5 or 6, and basically no chance of success with CR 7+.

In this game, a mage-type character with Strong Magic Affinity and Proficiency in Offense might ask to cast a fireball at an enemy. Fireball* would normally not be available until the character is 5th level (2 levels higher than the TPL). A DC of 25 puts it out of reach for most other characters and makes it difficult, but attainable for our mage. Since failing to meet the DC results in a wasted spell slot, the attempt is high risk but high reward. The same mage attempting to cast a ranged insta-kill spell (something equivalent to a 7th level Finger of Death or 9th level Power Word: Kill) should have a DC of 33 or higher, or simply inform them they haven’t learned how to access magic that powerful. It is unlikely that a PC with Weak Magic Affinity and/or no Proficiency in Offense will attempt even the fireball, since their probability of success is slim to none.

*Important Note: There are no defined attacks, weapons, spells, spell lists, or even classes in this ruleset. Players simply describe what they want to attempt and the DM determines the best fit for Affinities, Proficiencies and DC and asks for a roll. (Creative players might propose alternative Affinity/Proficiency combinations which the DM should allow if plausible.)

Common Questions and Recommendations:

Magic and Spells: any time a player wishes to use magic to produce an effect, they should mark off a single spell slot on their character sheet, regardless of the potency of the effect. This “mechanic” is self-balancing due to the DC scaling with the potency. A more powerful effect is more likely to fail, (and therefore waste the slot) particularly when attempted by a character without Strong Magic Affinity. A Paladin style character with Weak Magic Affinity is more likely to use magic for minor combat buffs or healing than for throwing fireballs.

A failed spell attempt has no effect other than wasting a spell slot **unless** a Natural 1 is rolled, which deals 1